



CHINESE NEW YEAR
Hidden beneath the costume of a fantastic lion with huge swivelling eyes, performers dance to bring good luck for the new year.



VENICE CARNIVAL
On the last day of this annual two-week public event in Venice, people crowd the streets wearing elaborate masks and costumes.

MARCH

The feast of St Patrick, patron saint of Ireland, falls on 17 March. The day of Holi, the Hindu spring festival, changes each year. The Jewish holiday of Purim varies, too, according to the Hebrew calendar.



ST PATRICK'S DAY
Many Irish people wear green on their saint's day, and celebrate with music and parades.



HOLI
Whatever the date of Holi, the fun is the same as people bombard each other with coloured powders and water.

PURIM
Shaking a wooden rattle is part of the religious service for Purim. The day remembers how Jewish people in ancient Persia escaped a deadly plot against them.



APRIL

Beware of practical jokers on 1 April, a day for making "April Fools" of everyone – or "April Fish" in France. More solemn are the major events of the Christian and Jewish calendars.



POISSON D'AVRIL (APRIL FISH)
On 1 April, children in France pin pictures of fish on their friends' backs for a joke.

PASSOVER
This festival remembers the freeing of the Jewish people from slavery 3,000 years ago. People eat a special meal including an egg, herbs, and a lamb bone.



EASTER
The Christian holiday celebrates Jesus Christ's resurrection after his crucifixion. Gifts of chocolate or sugar eggs symbolize rebirth.

JUNE



In northern regions, midsummer's day falls between 20 and 22 June. Many people mark the date with celebrations at sunrise. The start of the Muslim holy period of Ramadan can be in late June – the date depends on the rising of a new moon.



MIDSUMMER
The prehistoric monument of Stonehenge, on Salisbury Plain in Wiltshire, England, is a traditional place to watch the sun rise as midsummer's day dawns.



APPLE FLOWER FESTIVAL, DENMARK
Held on the small Danish island of Lilleø, this tiny festival celebrates the blossoming of the fruit trees.



WHITE NIGHTS FESTIVAL, ST PETERSBURG
An eagerly awaited highlight of the festival is the appearance on the Neva River of a sailing ship with bright scarlet sails.

People have long celebrated the warmer days and spring growth that come with May. During the three week White Nights festival in St Petersburg, Russia, revellers can stay up as late as they like – the nights are never completely dark at this time of year.

MAY



MAY DAY
In an age-old ritual, many British village communities erect a maypole on 1 May. The ribbons are wound round the pole as part of a dance.

MAY DAY WAS FIRST CELEBRATED BY THE ANCIENT ROMANS IN HONOUR OF FLORA, GODDESS OF FLOWERS



NOVEMBER

On Thanksgiving Day, Americans follow the tradition of the early European settlers, who gave thanks for the harvest every year. Today, Thanksgiving is mainly a family feast. In Mexico, people think of loved ones on the Day of the Dead – a time for happy memories.

DAY OF THE DEAD, MEXICO
During this festival on 2 November, people buy paper skeletons and eat sugar skulls.



THANKSGIVING
Figures from early American history parade in New York on Thanksgiving Day.

DECEMBER

In many countries and cultures, Christmas, Christ's birthday, is the time that children most look forward to, as they can expect presents and special food. There are also presents, games, and feasts at Hanukkah, the Jewish Festival of Lights, which often falls in December.

CHRISTMAS
A tree has been part of traditional Christmas celebrations for possibly hundreds of years.



HANUKKAH
One candle is lit on each day of this eight-day Jewish festival.

